



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 45

# UTAH

## WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

*Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Utah's family courts and child-welfare system.*

---

# 40

UTAH FAMILIES ON RECORD · 69  
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 6 MONTHS  
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING  
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 11, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

13 OF 29

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

# UTAH AT A GLANCE.

Across 40 Utah families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

|                                                                                               |                                                                                                                   |                                                                         |                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>CHILDREN IMPACTED</div> <div>69</div> <div>39 of 40 families reported child counts</div> | <div>MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN</div> <div>\$145,600</div> <div>median across 24 families reporting 3+ categories</div> | <div>MEDIAN MONTHS LOST</div> <div>6</div> <div>of parenting time</div> | <div>WENT PRO SE</div> <div>55.0%</div> <div>52.5% after running out of money</div> |
| <div>SUBMISSIONS</div> <div>40</div>                                                          | <div>AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY</div> <div>1.8</div>                                                                   | <div>FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN</div> <div>39 of 40</div>              | <div>COUNTIES REPRESENTED</div> <div>13</div>                                       |

## WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Utah families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF UTAH FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY                                           | RESPONSES | MEDIAN    | MEAN      | TOTAL REPORTED |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|----------------|
| Attorney Fees                                              | 29        | \$20,700  | \$44,748  | \$1,297,700    |
| Lost Wages                                                 | 24        | \$47,000  | \$90,938  | \$2,182,500    |
| Other Court Fees                                           | 13        | \$2,500   | \$8,581   | \$111,550      |
| Therapy / Evaluations                                      | 19        | \$2,600   | \$5,843   | \$111,009      |
| Reunification Services                                     | 11        | \$750     | \$4,117   | \$45,284       |
| GAL Fees                                                   | 17        | \$2,500   | \$5,359   | \$91,100       |
| Asset Loss                                                 | 22        | \$54,000  | \$233,959 | \$5,147,100    |
| Median Family Burden (24 families reporting 3+ categories) | —         | \$145,600 | —         | —              |

**Median vs. mean:** Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

|                           |                        |              |
|---------------------------|------------------------|--------------|
| Median months lost        | <div><div></div></div> | 6 0.5 yrs    |
| Mean months lost          | <div><div></div></div> | 18 1.5 yrs   |
| Total across all families | <div><div></div></div> | 556 46.3 yrs |

## 03 WHO IS REPORTING · UTAH

Most families documenting in Utah are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

## CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

## CASE STATUS

|                                    |  |    |     |
|------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Active case: stuck or delayed      |  | 24 | 60% |
| Case closed: within last 2 years   |  | 7  | 18% |
| Not provided                       |  | 4  | 10% |
| Active case: progress being made   |  | 2  | 5%  |
| Case closed: more than 2 years ago |  | 2  | 5%  |

## SYSTEM AFFECTED

|                                       |  |    |     |
|---------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Both Family Court and CPS             |  | 23 | 57% |
| Family Court Only                     |  | 12 | 30% |
| CPS (Child Protective Services) Only  |  | 2  | 5%  |
| Unknown                               |  | 2  | 5%  |
| Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF) |  | 1  | 2%  |

## DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

## TIME IN SYSTEM

|                    |  |    |     |
|--------------------|--|----|-----|
| 3 – 5 years        |  | 12 | 30% |
| 1 – 3 years        |  | 8  | 20% |
| 5 – 10 years       |  | 7  | 18% |
| 6 months – 1 year  |  | 5  | 12% |
| Less than 6 months |  | 4  | 10% |

## CUSTODY STATUS

|                                   |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Visitation Only                   |  | 13 | 32% |
| 50/50 Joint                       |  | 11 | 28% |
| No Contact / Total Loss of Access |  | 6  | 15% |
| Full Custody                      |  | 5  | 12% |
| Children in Foster Care           |  | 3  | 8%  |

## GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

## TOP COUNTIES

|             |  |   |     |
|-------------|--|---|-----|
| Salt Lake   |  | 9 | 22% |
| Weber       |  | 5 | 12% |
| Davis       |  | 5 | 12% |
| Iron        |  | 2 | 5%  |
| West Jordan |  | 1 | 2%  |
| Juab        |  | 1 | 2%  |

## TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

|                                                                             |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)         |  | 17 | 42% |
| False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report) |  | 8  | 20% |
| High Conflict Divorce                                                       |  | 7  | 18% |
| Other                                                                       |  | 3  | 8%  |
| Other: (Short answer)                                                       |  | 2  | 5%  |

## 04 PARENT VOICES — UTAH

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Utah comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



*CPS took my kids for 10 months because they spoke up about abuse the other parent was doing. They said I coached my kids even though I had hospital records and PO from another judge still fighting for sole custody especially because my ex wanted our children to stay in foster [...]*

— HALEY

## ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Access to children only to abuser( my ex husband) denied regular updates and photos as entitled to after termination of rights

— UTAH PARENT · CHERYL

## MORE VOICES FROM UTAH

They have stripped all forms of safety from my child and myself. I went through domestic violence, it's not physical anymore, but all other forms. I trust no one. You must be an abuser of elderly, women, and children to be protected by the court. I would be heard and listened [...]

— MELONIE

Complete psychological terrorism. My adult daughters testified in court against my ex (who also abused them), the judge gas lit them, discredited their testimonies. After his corrupt ruling, they both said to me "I'm never having kids". Destroyed their future and hopes for [...]

— LIZ

Document and record everything. I have cameras in my home now to protect myself and my children from false accusations.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Absolutely destroyed our family dynamic and the deep bond our children had shared with me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Wedge between me and my kids, false accusations. Long term mediation resulting in supervised visitations. Paid.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has kept me and my children in a prolonged, high-conflict process where repeated litigation, delays, and enforcement gaps have allowed instability to continue instead of creating lasting protection and consistency in which it's supposed to be intended [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*They have created trauma that never needed to happen. Then gave them to the people creating the trauma.*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has robbed me of time with my daughter. That can never be replaced or given back, Memory's that I won't have .

— RACHEL

Incentivizes DIVORCE and the breakup of families, RAPES mostly good men/fathers of being fathers to their children and of money/income to take care of their kids and themselves for the rest of their lives. Places their kids in HIGH RISK categories of crime, depression, suicide [...]

— CHRIS

Utah Courts are known as the judicial industrial complex. It's a farce and creates acrimony and billable hours. Judges hands are not clean.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex has admitted to domestic violence in his court documents, he has been high on drugs around kids and court looking to give him 50/50 through a GAL, while making me pay for psych evals. GAL came out in favor for dad without even talking to me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Let the one who hates the most, has the most money, and uses our children, be rewarded with the privilege of raising our children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This has tore our family apart. Some of the saddest most painful moments I have ever been through.

— JIM

This system abused my babies and I for financial gain. Lied and abused power because I tried to stand up, we did nothing wrong and was still punched.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Court ordered that my two boys go live with their unemployed father who has a Protective Order (and has been arrested) after he coached them to tell a therapist I was abusive. Even the therapist said the children's stories didn't make sense, but she had to report regardless.

— ELIZABETH

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*They have destroyed me and my daughters life. I don't know what to do or how I can fix any of this. I am up against monsters that don't play by the rules.*

— IVY

My kids are still at risk and I have to come up with more money to make sure he cant have custody as he is a abusive, addict with mental issues. If something were to happen to me they would have to go with him and he will ruin them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has allowed a safety net to be manipulated and turned into a weapon- the emergency ex-parte TRO. The system allowed my abuser to continue his abuse post-separation by exploiting legal measures meant to protect victims. Even when truth comes to light and the cases are [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We almost lost our twins boys to an accidental house fire. After finally getting to return home after the boys were discharged from several weeks of being on life support, DCFS removes the children due to allegations of homelessness and non supervision. It's been 2 months away [...]

— SHYANNA

At a time when our family needed one another the most, they separated us. The results, the outcome, the irresponsibility, unfathomable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Haven't held my boys sing may 8 th 3021. Haven't had one moment of connection. Now we are strangers. Now they are weapons to hurt me and nothing more. They are now motherless and I am alone

— KACIE

It's too painful to type in one box. Ive been put through three custody evaluations so far. Looking at a fourth. Has gone on for 15 years in two states with two different exes teaming up to lie for each other to get out of child support

— ANGELA

**04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED**

*DCFS lied and stole my daughter 6 years old even though I was doing everything asked of me. I lost my job, entire family exiled me, my will to live is almost gone.*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused serious emotional and psychological damage to both siblings as well as myself and our family. We have done absolutely nothing that should have had my child removed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex husband has taken everything he threatened to with the exception of the lives of the children and I. I am terrified to fight back because I recognize all prior threats made were followed through on. I have to choose between staying silent or risking him ending our lives. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has repeatedly prioritized procedural disputes and allegations over documented concerns about my child's safety, forcing me into ongoing legal battles while I continue to follow professional guidance and report disclosures appropriately. As a result, my [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Reprimanded me for kissing my newborn after 4 hours of un-medicated labor, threatened with jail time due to false allegations alienation, callously told me to "just pump" rather than being able to breastfeed my infant, lost full custody due to false allegations of alienation [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

29 Utah parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 29 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — UTAH**

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Utah families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

CPS took my kids for 10 months because they spoke up about abuse the other parent was doing. They said I coached my kids even though I had hospital records and PO from another judge still fighting for sole custody especially because my ex wanted our children to stay in foster care.

— HALEY

They have stripped all forms of safety from my child and myself. I went through domestic violence, it's not physical anymore, but all other forms. I trust no one. You must be an abuser of elderly, women, and children to be protected by the court. I would be heard and listened too in a criminal case more. The family system is not family focused and they support generational trauma. The moms can't work, but have to sole provide with no child support. The judges exact words to me, "you are definitely not safe around him (my ex) but your child is". What??? My child is in survival mode with his so called father. He has stomach issues and anxiety and teachers make comments of his confidence. And the court thinks that is not abuse? I hate the family court, they clearly are ignorant. Trained to spot abusers, not victims, they have zero clue of DARVO. It's shockingly embarrassing and very scary.

— MELONIE

Complete psychological terrorism. My adult daughters testified in court against my ex (who also abused them), the judge gas lit them, discredited their testimonies. After his corrupt ruling, they both said to me "I'm never having kids". Destroyed their future and hopes for healthy families, etc. Allowed my two little ones to be abused repeatedly and their father given full protection and immunity from investigation and accountability.

— LIZ

Access to children only to abuser( my ex husband) denied regular updates and photos as entitled to after termination of rights

— CHERYL

Document and record everything. I have cameras in my home now to protect myself and my children from false accusations.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

Absolutely destroyed our family dynamic and the deep bond our children had shared with me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Wedge between me and my kids, false accusations. Long term mediation resulting in supervised visitations. Paid.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has kept me and my children in a prolonged, high-conflict process where repeated litigation, delays, and enforcement gaps have allowed instability to continue instead of creating lasting protection and consistency in which it's supposed to be intended for. So far it has given an abuser temporary custody, now he's trying to take it again for false reasons, with the gal on his side. It has forced me to parent under constant scrutiny and emotional strain while my children remain exposed to financial strain uncertainty, conflict their father won't stop, and avoidable disruption to their wellbeing due to him being allowed to bring me to court every year.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have created trauma that never needed to happen. Then gave them to the people creating the trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has robbed me of time with my daughter. That can never be replaced or given back, Memory's that I won't have .

— RACHEL

Incentivizes DIVORCE and the breakup of families, RAPES mostly good men/fathers of being fathers to their children and of money/income to take care of their kids and themselves for the rest of their lives. Places their kids in HIGH RISK categories of crime, depression, suicide, and future happiness being good citizens of the country - a plague on society.

— CHRIS

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

Utah Courts are known as the judicial industrial complex. It's a farce and creates acrimony and billable hours. Judges hands are not clean.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex has admitted to domestic violence in his court documents, he has been high on drugs around kids and court looking to give him 50/50 through a GAL, while making me pay for psych evals. GAL came out in favor for dad without even talking to me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Let the one who hates the most, has the most money, and uses our children, be rewarded with the privilege of raising our children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This has tore our family apart. Some of the saddest most painful moments I have ever been through.

— JIM

This system abused my babies and I for financial gain. Lied and abused power because I tried to stand up, we did nothing wrong and was still punched.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Court ordered that my two boys go live with their unemployed father who has a Protective Order (and has been arrested) after he coached them to tell a therapist I was abusive. Even the therapist said the children's stories didn't make sense, but she had to report regardless.

— ELIZABETH

They have destroyed me and my daughters life. I don't know what to do or how I can fix any of this. I am up against monsters that don't play by the rules.

— IVY

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

My kids are still at risk and I have to come up with more money to make sure he cant have custody as he is a abusive, addict with mental issues. If something were to happen to me they would have to go with him and he will ruin them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has allowed a safety net to be manipulated and turned into a weapon- the emergency ex-parte TRO. The system allowed my abuser to continue his abuse post-separation by exploiting legal measures meant to protect victims. Even when truth comes to light and the cases are dismissed, there is no consequence for the acting party.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We almost lost our twins boys to an accidental house fire. After finally getting to return home after the boys were discharged from several weeks of being on life support, DCFS removes the children due to allegations of homelessness and non supervision. It's been 2 months away from our babies, adjudication trial on the 12th of May..

— SHYANNA

At a time when our family needed one another the most, they separated us. The results, the outcome, the irresponsibility, unfathomable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Haven't held my boys since may 8 th 2021. Haven't had one moment of connection. Now we are strangers. Now they are weapons to hurt me and nothing more. They are now motherless and I am alone

— KACIE

It's too painful to type in one box. Ive been put through three custody evaluations so far. Looking at a fourth. Has gone on for 15 years in two states with two different exes teaming up to lie for each other to get out of child support

— ANGELA

**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED**

DCFS lied and stole my daughter 6 years old even though I was doing everything asked of me. I lost my job, entire family exiled me, my will to live is almost gone.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused serious emotional and psychological damage to both siblings as well as myself and our family. We have done absolutely nothing that should have had my child removed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My ex husband has taken everything he threatened to with the exception of the lives of the children and I. I am terrified to fight back because I recognize all prior threats made were followed through on. I have to choose between staying silent or risking him ending our lives. It's no place for any parent or child to exist in.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has repeatedly prioritized procedural disputes and allegations over documented concerns about my child's safety, forcing me into ongoing legal battles while I continue to follow professional guidance and report disclosures appropriately. As a result, my family has experienced emotional, financial, and psychological strain while I work to protect my child and maintain stability in the face of repeated motions, accusations, and delayed responses to evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Reprimanded me for kissing my newborn after 4 hours of un-medicated labor, threatened with jail time due to false allegations alienation, callously told me to "just pump" rather than being able to breastfeed my infant, lost full custody due to false allegations of alienation, lost medical authority due false allegations of non-compliance in with medical records.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

29 full approved Utah comments are included in this appendix.

## 06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

### WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Utah report comes from Utah respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Utah — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 40 Utah families reporting here are not the universe of Utah families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

### METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through [standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey](https://standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey). Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

### ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.